HARDIK CHHABRA



BURNING PROBLEM (Left) AAP leaders at an anti-NEET protest, Jun. 18

Several petitions have been submitted to the high courts and the Supreme Court citing the arbitrary grace marks, the peculiar jump in the number of high scorers and even the possibility of paper leaks. As Alakh Pandey, petitioner and CEO of PhysicsWallah, asks, "The question is, what if there are other discrepancies we are unaware of?" On June 11, Pandey had moved the SC against the arbitrary award of grace marks, saying the NTA's explanation does not hold. The petition had the signatures of 20,000 students and included evidence that 70-80 marks had been randomly awarded to some candidates. In parallel, the possibility of a paper leak began gathering force.

THE PAPER LEAK TRAIL

Many began questioning why students from Haryana, Bihar, Maharashtra, Jharkhand and Karnataka appeared for NEET at an obscure centre in Gujarat's Godhra. Blowing the lid off a multi-crore cheating scam, the Gujarat police have now unearthed details of how at least 26 students from across the country paid Rs 10 lakh to Rs 66 lakh each to clear the NEET exam. The scam ran at three ends—one allegation involved a Vadodara-based coaching class Roy Overseas run by Parshuram Roy; the principal of Jay Jalaram school in Godhra (the exam centre), Purshottam Sharma; and a teacher at the school and designated deputy superintendent for the centre, Tushar Bhatt. The students accused of cheating were to fill in the answers they knew; the teachers would fill in the blanks after the answer key was released. But here too, after the initial investigations and an FIR being filed on May 9, no further revelations were made in the case till the Supreme Court clubbed an appeal seeking a CBI inquiry into the Godhra paper leak case with other NEET-related petitions from across the country. That's when five of the accused were arrested on June 13.

A similar racket has come to light in Patna, Bihar. A search of junior engineer Sikandar Yadav's vehicle on May 5 in the city yielded copies of four NEET admit cards and other documents. The 56-year-old employee of the Danapur Nagar Parishad confessed he had received the NEET questions before the exam and named four accomplices—Sanjeev Singh, Rocky, Nitish and Amit Anand. Based on their confessions, investigators discovered that the gang members had rented rooms in a boys' hostel and a school in Patna, where some 40 students memorised the answers a day before the NEET exam. The police raided the location and recovered burnt question papers, along with admit cards, post-dated cheques worth Rs 2.3 crore and educational certificates of the students which the gang had confiscated as surety. Sources say each candidate was asked to pay Rs 30-50 lakh. The gang took advance payments of Rs 1 lakh from the students. Upon receiving the paper, the students were taken to a safe house at night to memorise the answers. So far, the police have arrested 13 people, including four candidates who took the NEET test. Thirty-five other students have been called in for questioning.

109,170
NO. OF SEATS
for MBBS on offer this year in the 706 medical colleges in India

2.4
MILLION
students across 4,750 centres in 571 cities took NEET (some 400,000 more than last year)

67
NO. OF STUDENTS
who got the full score of 720 in the 2024 NEET exam

1,563
NO. OF STUDENTS
who got grace marks in NEET test (since revoked)

THE PROBE AND OTHER DISCREPANCIES

The NTA had constituted a panel of three experts to look into the cases reported, including impersonation, cheating and tampering with the OMR (optical mark recognition) sheet, says director-general Subodh Kumar Singh. The inquiry apparently found that 63 students used unfair means and they have since been debarred or their scores withheld. However, the DG also told agencies that "the sanctity of the medical entrance exam has not been compromised...there has been no paper leak". The petitioners, though,